Jharkhand's first non-tribal head of government. But Soren knows implementing the two decisions will be easier said than done. That's why his next move will be to shift the onus on the BJP. Once ratified in the assembly, the policies will be sent to the Centre with a request to include these in the Ninth Schedule to firewall them against judicial review (barring any violation of fundamental rights or the basic structure of the Constitution). If the Centre agrees, the Soren regime will gather credit. In case it rejects the moves or pussyfoots around them, the blame will go the other way. Both tribal groups—the state's *moolnivasis* (original inhabitants), roughly 26.3 per cent of the population—and the OBCs will be watching. Soren, whose Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) already has a strong support base among the tribals, is making a play for a wider votebase: the OBCs range up to 46 per cent. It's Jharkhand's Mandal moment.

Soren has been on a please-all mission ever since it became clear he may be forced to craft a future anew. Earlier, he had revived the old pension scheme for government employees from September, which guarantees 50 per cent of the last drawn salary as pension (the new scheme is market-linked and, therefore, offers uncertain returns). Soren has also cleared proposals to give a month's additional salary and 20 days' compensatory paid leave to police personnel, and approved paid study leave for state administrative service officers. In another initiative, the field firing range in Netarhat was not renotified, in line with a longstanding demand of thousands of tribals in Latehar and Gumla districts.

Late last month, Soren was desperate to keep his flock together. Fearing a plot to wean away ruling alliance MLAs, on August 30, he moved 31 of them to Congress-ruled Chhattisgarh. But he shifted tack soon and brought the MLAs back to Ranchi for the confidence motion. This appears to have done wonders to his confidence too. Soren last week met the governor, asking him to clear the confusion over the EC's word. Jharkhand has seen 11 CMs and three spells of President's rule since its formation in November 2000. It may see a 12th one if Soren gets disqualified. But his eyes seem set on a larger clock. ■

RAJASTHAN

PILOT FACES TURBULENCE

By Rohit Parihar



The occasion was sombre, yet politically significant. Members of the Gujjar community had reached Pushkar, about 150 kilometres west of Jaipur, on September 12, to take part in a mass meeting and pay tributes to Colonel Kirori Singh Bainsla, the man who gained a manner of iconic status after leading the agitation to demand special reservation for the community in Rajasthan.

But what was expected to be a show of strength for Gujjars—who can influence election results in at least a dozen eastern seats of the 200-member assembly—was marred by ugly scenes. Two cabinet ministers belonging to the community were heckled by the crowd. Shoes flew in the air, as did imprecations. The fissures that lay revealed centre upon the figure of former deputy chief minister Sachin Pilot, almost an undisputed leader of the Gujjars in Rajasthan. The community, of course, has rarely had a sole leader, until Bainsla, a retired army officer, took it upon himself to unite them about a decade and a half ago for the special status agitation. But even he had failed to translate that into political benefits. Fighting on a BJP ticket in 2009, he lost the Lok Sabha election by a whisker.

Long before he passed away this March, Sachin had filled that vacuum by emerging as a popular leader of the community. Named Rajasthan Congress president in 2014, he played a pivotal role in the party's win in 2018 and was sworn in as deputy CM. However, an attempted coup against CM Ashok Gehlot in 2020 cost him both the posts. Now, after divisions within the party have become public knowledge and with the stakes rising as each day brings election closer, the rivalry between the two leaders has roiled the waters so much, it's looking like a free-for-all, where Sachin's claim to the mantle of community leadership is being set up to be challenged. The shoes in the air were apparently a

WEST BENGAL

RED DAWN RISING

By Romita Datta

It was a near-forgotten sight—College Street *boipara* (book market), the education hub of Kolkata, awash with red. Left flags with the hammer-sickle-star and buntings with Che Guevara's silhouette were back. So was the colour that once ruled the city, then consigned to relative obscurity over the past decade following the Trinamool Congress's overwhelming presence in political signage. The afternoon was a flashback from an earlier era.